

Chapter 3

Liam's blades cut thin lines through the ice as he skated seamlessly, keeping to the inside 'track' of the rink. On a public session, most furs skated clockwise around the rink, keeping close to the wall as if afraid to take steps into the unknown. The otter, however, skated against the flow and had no trouble avoiding beginners and the ambitious who strayed closer to the centre, dipping amongst the hair flipping figure skaters. His tail flicked and he stiffened it the best he could, using it as a partial rudder to guide his path. It was of more use in water than on the ice, though it gave him a greater edge over other skaters. Otters were most certainly not only suited to water.

Striking off his left skate, he changed direction, cutting sharply across the centre of the rink and smoother ice. A wolf pup with a penguin 'ice buddy', which allowed him some support on which to lean while on the ice, toppled over on his tail and wailed, a piercing shriek that echoed across the rink. Liam winced and resisted the urge to press his paws over his ears. Normally he would have been expected to pick up the fallen pup, comfort him and check him over for injuries, but not today. A day off was not for work even if he was still at the rink. Why, it was practically his second home.

Kyle waved at him from the side of the rink, standing in front of the large doors that hid the zamboni at the far end of the rink. The fox smoothed the fur back on his head, paw half-raised until he was quite sure that Liam had seen him, and ducked into the store room where the majority of their equipment for maintaining the rink was kept. The tools of their trade from as simple as brooms for sweeping up crushed ice from the edge of the rink to the nets used for ice hockey games. The door could be raised and lowered by use of a remote control to keep it secluded from the rest of the rink; a zamboni, after all, was used to take a layer of ice from the rink and was dangerous for the public to be around, no matter how slow it was.

Smirking, Liam turned on his heel with a flick of his tail, shooting to the more populated end of the rink in a spray of ground up ice. Cool air ruffled his fur in passing, welcome relief from the heat seeping from his bare arms. It was strange to be so hot in such a cold environment yet he relished it, finding a kind of solitude in the peace of solo skating. Though it would have still been fun to have company to skate, he mused. It was easier to pause to cool down or take a break when others were around. He had only been skating for a half hour and already his t-shirt stuck to his back from sweat. Liam grinned, revelling in the speed and ability of his body.

Whipping around a teetering, white feline, he settled into some basic personal practice, stopping and starting off the edge of his blades in quick succession. He changed the hind paw on which he struck off every other turn, furrowing his brow in concentration. Sweat trickled through his fur and he huffed, focusing on the movement and increasing his speed on every run through. He was fit enough from skating but it took a great deal of muscle strength to stop on a dime, legs trembling as he worked them to the bone. He had no particular reason to hone his skill, but his own enjoyment in the practice. It was good to simply be good. And to be better.

Panting heavily from the short but intense burst of motion, Liam glided in to the wall, avoiding a struggling equine with a startling palomino coat – she seemed too light against the ice, dressed in cool, blue fabrics. He tucked himself in neatly behind the mare's tail, chuckling to no one in particular as the horse skittered, legs shooting apart as if she was

attempting the splits. They had skates especially designed for hooves available for hire at the rink, of course, but it seemed that time and time again ice and hooves did not mix at all well.

He leaned against the perimeter wall, which cut off between his chest and waist, low enough so that he could prop his elbows up to watch the other skaters with ease. While he did not enjoy tending to public sessions as an employee at the rink, beginners and those simply out for a good time were amusing to watch, as long as they paid him no mind. He licked his lips, finding them dry and his throat parched.

Never one to buy expensive single serving soft drinks, he grumbled at the thought of popping home for a glass of water – from the tap, of course. Liam wondered if Kyle would look kindly on him today and let him dash into the staff room for a quick cup from the water dispenser? He licked his lips again, seeking moisture that he would not find. He could never tell what mood the older fox would be in on any given day. He was a hard one to judge.

“Fancy seeing you here.”

Liam jumped and fought for balance, blades sliding wildly over the ice. His heart hammered against his ribcage as he more cautiously ducked away from the wall, circling to face the boards with a wary eye. An all too familiar muzzle parted in an open-mouthed grin, a flash of unnerving white teeth framing his culprit.

Liam stared at the wolf without blinking. The canine’s fur stood up at an odd angle from his head as if he had been wearing a helmet, the fur behind his ears matted down to his skull. A tuft of thicker fur protruded from the neck of his t-shirt, which was tastefully fitted to show off the lines of muscle in his chest.

The otter shook himself and frowned. He still had not replied to the wolf, waiting for his heartbeat to return to some semblance of normal. Even after his surprise, it thwarted his attempts to slow, breaths coming in patient, steady inhalations. Strange. That usually worked.

“Yes,” he finally said. “Fancy seeing an ice hockey player at an ice rink. A strange occurrence indeed, you could say.”

The wolf’s ears lowered, drooping to the sides of his head.

“All right,” he muttered, lips turning down sullenly. “Fair point. Just figured I’d say hi, that’s all.”

He paced down the outside of the rink, a pair of sleek skates dangling from his paw, emblazoned with a red logo that Liam did not quite catch. Darren’s shoulders hunched forward and his lips set into a thin line. He shrugged as if to let a weight roll off his shoulders and the otter’s heart grimaced with guilt. Why was it so easy to be sharp when he never meant to be? Goddamn sarcasm! It would be the death of him, he was sure.

“Hey!”

He raced along the boards, dodging a stumbling lion, whose claws were dangerously outstretched, tawny arms flailing as he lost and gained his balance every other second. The otter cursed under his breath, striking speed into his legs. All the bad skaters were out that

day! He needed to be quicker. Chasing Darren, who walked on the other side of the boards with fewer hindrances in his path, Liam puffed for breath, cheeks flushing red beneath his fur.

Much to his relief, the wolf paused halfway down the length of the rink, ears pricked to catch the sound of Liam's approach. He curled his paw around the back of his neck, elbow jutting up into the air as he waited for the otter to speak. When no words were forthcoming, he raised an eyebrow.

"What?"

Liam almost fled but held firm against all odds, heart fidgeting with irregular beats. He knew it was only his imagination, his mind playing tricks on him, though it felt as if the organ was going to burst from his chest. He took a moment to compose himself, chasing the negativity from his mind. It would be so much easier to run, to bugger off, yet something kept him in place, catching his breath. He yearned for a friendly voice and, before his humour had come off badly, the wolf had been that, a drop of water in the desert. After the last skating tiff with 'Neil and Co.', the only furs he had had contact with had been the ones at work. It was not enough for a solitary otter.

He gulped and steadied himself.

"I didn't mean to come off like that," he said at last, the long pause shattered. "Bit too sarcastic for my own good at times. You know...how it is..."

He trailed off, fumbling with his own words. Darren eyed the otter carefully.

"What was the other night about then?"

Liam nipped the inside of his cheek, drawing a spot of blood. He was terrible for doing that, gnawing the inside of his mouth until it bled. If he had still been going to the dentist, he would have been told off.

"You kind of accosted me, you know."

Liam laughed anxiously, scooting his heel across the ice in a grinding scrape as he toyed with the blade. The blade was dull and smooth, not the dangerous point it should have been; they needed sharpening again.

"I try not to involve myself in things, especially drama, and I reacted badly," he over explained, feeling increasingly daft by the second. "I mean, it wasn't as if I expected you to be there. You near enough jumped me."

It was all going terribly wrong. Liam's eyes grazed the wolf's and he looked away an instant later.

"What I mean to say is... I'm sorry for being a dick. Just had a stupid moment," he finished lamely, staring at the ice.

Darren rolled his shoulders, easing the tension from sore muscle, chin tipping up to expose a creamy furred throat. Liam's fingers twitched.

"Ah, it's no bother really. No big deal."

The otter smiled, relief washing over him.

"Well...good. Glad to hear that. Great."

Darren shuffled, swapping his skates over to his other paw.

"Was watching you skate," Darren broke the silence. "You're pretty damn good."

"Oh...thank you?"

The otter rubbed his forearms, sweat chilling in the icy air. How did one respond to a compliment again? It had been a while. He tried a smile that the wolf, thankfully, returned.

"Been skating since I could remember," Liam offered accordingly. "When did you start? I bet it's been forever."

"Liked the hockey teams, used to watch with my father when I was younger. Just got into it and didn't stop, though it's not been long since I could skate properly. Mostly I just fell over."

Liam glanced back in time to see a slim ermine tumble on to her nose, red eyes blinking back tears in a sea of white fur. He would have darted over to help her – hey, even he was a sucker for a pretty lady rather than annoying cubs – but Kyle was already on his way, slipping in his street shoes over the ice. The otter exchanged a look with Darren, lips tugging up at the corner.

"Ah, not as bad as some," Liam chuckled.

Darren hesitated, gaze sliding away to watch the other skaters, though he paid the sniffing ermine no mind.

"Would you like to grab a drink?"

"Uh..." Liam rubbed the back of his neck sheepishly. "Sure, I'd like to, but I don't have any cash on me. Think I'll have to pass this time, though..." He threw caution to the wind – to hell with it! "Maybe next time? I'm here a *lot*."

The wolf waved his paw dismissively, beckoning him off the ice. As he moved his arm, his shirt pulled wonderfully tight across his chest, shoulders as round as two boulders atop his torso.

"Ah, don't worry about it. Figure I owe you, right? Else I'll start thinking you're trying to avoid me."

His grin was infectious and Liam could not find it in himself to feel his usual self-conscious self around the wolf. Slipping down the rink to a smaller gate that allowed furs on and off the ice, he exited carefully, balancing on the blades with a grunt. It always took him a few seconds to find his land legs again, as ungainly as a newborn foal for a time.

He followed the wolf back to the public lockers, which were each large enough for a pair of shoes and a few bits and bobs, set at the side of the rink where anyone could freely access them. Scrambling to remember his key code at the last minute, he tapped keys randomly until his body recalled the sequence over his mind. His muzzle flushed, little whiskers quivering and his paws were damp with sweat as he plopped down on a bench, struggling with the tight laces of his skates. The otter mumbled under his breath as he worked at the stubborn laces, bright red against the black of his boots, though darkened by dirt. He always forgot to take them off the skates on laundry day to wash them.

Darren only chuckled at his new friend's grumbled frustration and offered a paw to help him up when he was done.

"Impatient one, aren't you?"

Liam's nose twitched, muzzle wrinkling and he gave a half shrug.

"I like to get things done and get them done right."

The wolf led the way into the bar cafe some way down the lengthier side of the rink, stepping into the warmth with a soft sigh. A few other furs of various species were seated around circular tables on low chairs but it was more than quiet enough to talk unhindered without needing to raise one's voice. The interior was decorated in gold and red, rich and warming after the ice, and Liam relaxed, the buzz of conversation blissful white noise to his ears.

"So," Darren made his way to the bar at the right side of the room, the furthest spot from the door. "What'd you like?"

"Uh, just a water, please."

The otter smiled, hoping to appease. Oh, how he wished he'd brought his wallet with him for once! He twisted his paws in front of his stomach, running his fingers over the backs of the opposite paw in turn. It was always simply so *awkward* to have anyone else buy him a drink. Or buy him anything, for that matter.

"You know," he followed up hurriedly, "I don't have to have anything. Don't really want to make you pay for me."

A flash of mischief struck the wolf's muzzle and he held a paw to his forehead, eyes lidded as he pretended faintness.

"That was your master plan all along! I see it now! You lured me in...for a free drink!"

The absurdity made laughter bubble up from Liam's throat – it couldn't be held back.

“Yeah, that would be pretty ridiculous,” he agreed, understanding the strangeness of his ‘water’ request; he had not tricked the wolf into anything, he was quite right.

“Mhm...so what do you want then?”

Liam considered the options, raking his eyes over the bottles behind the bar and soft drinks on tap.

“Whatever you’re having will be fine, thank you,” he said, a little too politely. “You really didn’t have to.”

“All right!”

Darren studied his choices over the wooden bar top as the bartender, a portly bovine with a patchy black and white coat, stared at him sullenly. She gave no indication that he was there bar a flick of her tail, the tip tufted with black. Liam stifled a chuckle at her obstinacy, fighting to keep a straight face. Some furs really were true to their native species, it had to be said.

“Gin and tonic, please.” Darren smiled pleasantly, digging in his pocket for his wallet. “Two would be great, thank you.”

The cow studied him and slowly went through the motions of mixing up the drinks with the little they entailed. She chose lemonade as a mixer rather than tonic and, though Darren’s smile vanished, he accepted the two drinks graciously, paid up with a note and odd coins, gesturing to Liam to sit down.

Plopping into the chair with high arms, Liam shifted, trying to find a position that was comfortable. Darren sat opposite him with his legs outstretched, taking stock of his drink while he placed the other before Liam.

“Was hoping for a better drink,” Darren’s nostrils flared as he took a sip. “S’pose it tastes okay though.”

“Didn’t think you’d go for something alcoholic,” Liam mused, sipping the substitute G & T. “Thanks very much, you didn’t have to.”

“Don’t you drink then?”

Darren scratched his throat; Liam rushed to assure him.

“No, no, just don’t usually buy it for myself, that’s all.”

“How come?” Darren asked.

“Uh...” Liam slunk back into the low armchair, crossing his ankles over one another as if to draw himself away even further. “This will sound silly but it often seems a bit of a waste of money, to buy too much and drink alone, at least. I don’t usually drink out if I do have a beer or anything.”

The otter's paw quivered as he reached for the glass and he took a calculated sip, the warmth of light liquor tickling his throat. It felt so good as it slipped down and he remember all too well the lure of another glass, one more drink, on a lonely winter night.

Darren accepted his initial response without further probing as the otter mused. They sipped in companionable quiet, watching skaters fly and tumble over the rink beyond the windows, which ran the full length of the bar cafe.

"So... How do you feel about ice hockey?"

Darren was the first to break the peace with his coarser tones, rubbing the condensation off his glass in a series of downward strokes, turning it to catch every drop with the insistent pads of his fingers.

"It's interesting enough, I guess." Liam didn't know where to start or what was 'acceptable' to say. "You've got to have some sweet skating skill to do well at it, I would assume."

"Hah! We wish! To which I mean, 'not necessarily'."

Chuckling, the wolf shook his head.

"What do you mean?" Liam said.

"People join our team to play, not skate," the wolf explained, keen to share with his tongue half-lolling from his muzzle. "Some don't get that the two go paw in paw. Even if we are only an amateur team."

"Oh, really?" The otter raised an eyebrow, eyes glinting mischievously. "Would have thought you were a pro from how you acted outside the rink."

Darren had the good grace to appear moderately ashamed and he rubbed his nose, sniffing as if the cold had made it run.

"Yeah..." He admitted. "I can sometimes take the team too seriously. We're an amateur team and most are in it for a laugh. Me...I'm going professional, as soon as I can."

Liam stared rudely, his curiosity roused.

"You have a team after you already?" He asked, suitably impressed.

The wolf shook his head.

"No, this is the sort of thing I have to go at alone," he said. "Nothing comes easy, right? Need to train hard, play hard and work my way up. There will always be a way if you do the right research and work hard enough."

"Wow... Looks like you have it all figured out." Liam sat up straighter, slightly intimidated. "Never really met anyone with even a rough plan of making it big in...well...anything."

Darren studied him, replacing his glass on the table.

“You know,” he said, too casually. “You may want to think about joining the team. Your skating skill aside, I reckon you’ll find a few more like minds over there.”

He smirked, downing the rest of his drink as he gave the otter time to think. Liam blinked dully for several seconds and looked from left to right to check that no one had a camera in his face, recording a prank, before raising both eyebrows in sheer, uncontained shock. Him? Join an *ice hockey* team? He’d be flattened!

“What? But I’ve never played hockey before!” Liam burst, so startled that he forgot himself. “I’m not even big like the rest of the guys on your team. I’ve bloody seen them, you know!”

Darren laughed, throwing his head back, and the otter’s tail swayed, words failing him in spluttering silence. How was he supposed to respond to...that? He frowned, glancing at his half empty glass as if it would hold the answers he sought. The wolf shook with chuckles. Come on, he knew there was no right or wrong way to actually respond, the otter told himself. The idea itself was a farce. Liam sighed. Neil’s attitude must be really getting to him if he was thinking more and more along those lines.

Darren cleared his throat.

“Didn’t mean to laugh at you, mate, but not all the players are great big hulking hunks of muscle like yours truly here.”

He struck a pose, raising his arms above his head to flex with such an absurd grin that a giggle spilled from Liam’s lips before he could stop it. He clapped a paw over his muzzle, horrified at the girlish sound, but the damage was already done. Darren roared with laughter, crumpling forward over himself and slapping his knee. As he laughed, Liam’s chuckles grew into full fledged peals and he howled until there were tears in the eyes, uncaring of the other patrons looking at the two of them like they had lost their minds. If they thought badly of the two lads shrieking with mirth, Liam could not even bring himself to care, ribs aching something awful.

“Bloody hell,” Darren gasped, rubbing the back of his paw over his muzzle as he caught his breath. “You sounded like a ...like a...”

Liam rolled his eyes, though there was no bad feeling behind the action. Funny how that could be different under different circumstances. He felt bad for ever snapping at the wolf. It had been a long time since he had laughed until it hurt.

“Look, why don’t you come to our game later, see if you like the look of it. There’s one on later tonight.”

Darren tried to persuade him with a winning smile and Liam tilted his head to the side, considering. It would be most unlike him to jump into the unknown with nobody to back him up, but it seemed more and more that that was the only way anything was going to change if, like the wolf, he did it along. It was worth a shot to pop in to watch a game and there could be no obligations attached to it. He traced a circle on the table with one forefinger, spinning the beer bat around and around. It might even be fun.

“All right, you got me.” Liam held up his paws in mock defeat. “How much is it to come to the game? Is it here?”

Darren nodded.

“Free to watch, don’t worry. We pay ourselves for the ice time as a team,” Darren assured, his grin wide.

Liam’s small ears perked the best they could. Free? Well, he certainly could not see any harm in that! He wouldn’t even be put out and, whatever happened, watching the game would be free entertainment. He had to admit to himself that he was curious.

He gulped the last of his drink down, throat working, and settled the glass back on the table with a decisive clunk.

“It’s a done deal. What time’s...uh...kick off?”

Darren widened his eyes and clapped a paw to his forehead, an epic ‘face paw’ that even made Liam cringe. What was so wrong with ‘kick off’? Was that a different sport? He stuck his tongue out at the wolf who cast him a sly look.

“Oh boy. We’ve got a long way to go before the game! Now...a quick run through of what you’ll need to know...”